

"I DON'T HAVE TO REGRET ANYTHING. IF THERE IS ANYTHING TO REGRET, IT IS THAT SUCH A THING HAS BEFALLEN THE COUNTRY."

P. V. NARASIMHA RAO after the demolition of the Babri Masjid

TRYING TO PUT THE GENIE BACK



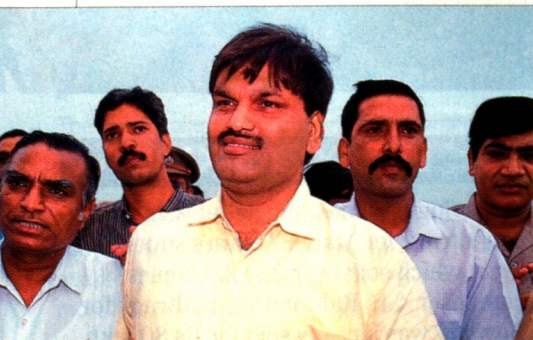
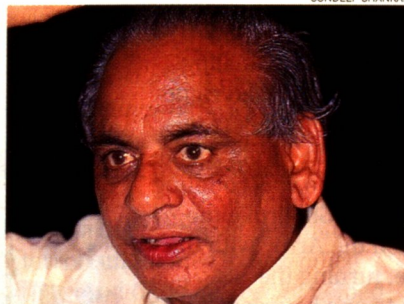
On December 5, former prime minister V.P. Singh, along with a host of Janata Dal and communist leaders, was arrested at Ram Sanehi Ghat in Barabanki district of Uttar Pradesh. They were on their way to Ayodhya to obtain a first-hand account of the Babri Masjid situation as it developed there. Singh recorded a detailed statement on the demolition with the Liberhan Commission of inquiry into the matter.

DESTROYER-IN-CHIEF

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Kalyan Singh was a vital cog in the machinery that eventually brought down the Babri Masjid. As the soft face of the BJP, he hoodwinked the Centre with false assurances and played on Narasimha Rao's near-obsession for constitutional propriety. And as the smoke of burning Muslim homes was beginning to cloud the horizon, he pre-empted the dismissal of his government by the Centre by resigning on December 6.

Kalyan Singh

SONDEEP SHANKAR



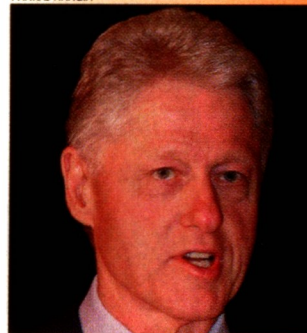
SHARAD SAXENA

"I'M LIVING HOUR TO HOUR."

Harshad Mehta was a small-time stockbroker on Dalal Street who became a self-made celebrity living in a palatial mansion with a golf course, swimming pool and a fleet of flashy cars. Arrested on June 4, the Big Bull is estimated to have siphoned off close to Rs 5,000 crore by manipulating banks and building false positions on a number of high value stocks. Mehta died of a heart attack in 2001.

- The Assembly of the Socialist Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina proclaimed independence from the Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia.
- Democrat candidate Bill Clinton became the 42nd president of the United States, defeating Republican incumbent George Bush. "There is nothing wrong with America today that cannot be cured by

PANKAJ NANGIA



what is right with America," he said in his inaugural speech after taking oath.

- Suspected Armenian forces massacred 613 Azerbaijani civilians in Khojaly.

25 lakh

was the number of people awaiting telephone connections on the eve of India's economic reforms. Today, over 206 million Indians own phones, including mobile connections. Fixed line phones have been dropping in number.